Point Defects in Crystals from Freysoldt *et al.*

Duy M. Dao

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1 The Formation Energy as a Grand Potential

Reservoirs and the grand potential. A crystal supercell exchanges atoms of each species i with a reservoir at the chemical potential μ_i, and exchanges electrons with a reservoir at the electron chemical potential, the Fermi level E_F. The reservoirs represent the surroundings of the supercell. They fix the temperature T and the chemical potentials, and the supercell has a fixed volume V. The Legendre transform of the internal energy U with the natural variables $(T, V, \{\mu_i\}, E_F)$ is the grand potential Φ. Here, N_i denotes the number of atoms of species i and N_e the number of electrons in the pristine supercell. The grand potential of the pristine supercell is

$$\Phi_{\text{bulk}} = U_{\text{bulk}} - TS_{\text{bulk}} - \sum_i \mu_i N_i - E_F N_e = F_{\text{bulk}} - \sum_i \mu_i N_i - E_F N_e.$$

Neutral defects. Here, n_i denotes the number of atoms of species i that enter the supercell to form the defect X. A positive n_i adds atoms, for example an interstitial, and a negative n_i removes atoms, for example a vacancy. The grand potential of the supercell with the defect is

$$\Phi[X] = F[X] - \sum_i \mu_i \left(N_i + n_i\right) - E_F N_e.$$

The formation energy of the defect is the change of the grand potential at fixed $(T, V, \{\mu_i\}, E_F)$,

$$\boxed{E^f[X] = \Phi[X] - \Phi_{\text{bulk}} = F[X] - F_{\text{bulk}} - \sum_i \mu_i n_i.} \tag{1.1}$$

The natural variables are the same before and after the defect forms, but $\Phi[X]$ and Φ_{bulk} describe two different systems, so the two values differ.

Charged defects. A defect in the charge state q, written X^q, has released q electrons to the electron reservoir, so the supercell holds $N_e - q$ electrons,

$$\Phi[X^q] = F[X^q] - \sum_i \mu_i \left(N_i + n_i\right) - E_F \left(N_e - q\right).$$

The terms in N_i and N_e cancel against Φ_{bulk}, and the formation energy is

$$\boxed{E^f[X^q] = F[X^q] - F_{\text{bulk}} - \sum_i \mu_i n_i + qE_F.} \tag{1.2}$$

Formation energy from DFT at 0 K. At $T = 0$, the free energy equals the internal energy, $F = U$. A DFT calculation gives the total energy E_{tot} of the supercell with the nuclei at rest. The nuclei still vibrate at $T = 0$, so the internal energy also contains the zero-point energy of the phonon modes. Here, $E_{\text{ZPE}} = \frac{1}{2}\sum_k \hbar\omega_k$ denotes the zero-point energy of a supercell with the phonon frequencies ω_k. With $U = E_{\text{tot}} + E_{\text{ZPE}}$, the formation energy reads

$$\boxed{E^f[X^q] = \big(E_{\text{tot}}[X^q] + E_{\text{ZPE}}[X^q]\big) - \big(E_{\text{tot}}[\text{bulk}] + E_{\text{ZPE}}[\text{bulk}]\big) - \sum_i \mu_i n_i + qE_F.} \tag{1.3}$$

The total energies come from the DFT calculations, and the zero-point energies from the phonon frequencies of the two supercells. The phonon frequencies scale as $M^{-1/2}$ with the nuclear mass M, and most modes are the same in both supercells, so the difference of the zero-point energies is negligible for heavy nuclei and matters mainly for light atoms such as hydrogen. The chemical potentials μ_i and the Fermi level E_F describe the reservoirs and enter as parameters.

2 Charge-State Transition Levels and the U Parameter

The formation energy as a function of the Fermi level. Here, $E_0^f[X^q]$ denotes the formation energy at $E_F = 0$, with E_F measured from the valence-band maximum (VBM). The formation energy of Section 1 depends on the Fermi level through the term qE_F only,

$$E^f[X^q] = E_0^f[X^q] + qE_F.$$

In a plot against E_F, each charge state is a straight line with the slope q. At a given E_F, the defect takes the charge state with the lowest formation energy, so the stable charge state follows the lower envelope of the lines (red in Fig. 1). The Fermi level ranges from the VBM to the conduction-band minimum (CBM).

Charge-state transition levels. The charge-state transition level $\varepsilon(q/q')$ is the Fermi level at which the charge states q and q' have equal formation energies. Equating the two lines gives

$$\boxed{\varepsilon(q/q') = \frac{E_0^f[X^{q'}] - E_0^f[X^q]}{q - q'}.} \tag{2.1}$$

Below $\varepsilon(q/q')$, the more positive charge state is stable, and above $\varepsilon(q/q')$, the more negative one is stable. The transition levels are the kinks of the lower envelope.

The stability window of a charge state. Three consecutive charge states $q+1$, q and $q-1$ have two transition levels, $\varepsilon(q+1/q) = E_0^f[X^q] - E_0^f[X^{q+1}]$ and $\varepsilon(q/q-1) = E_0^f[X^{q-1}] - E_0^f[X^q]$. The charge state q is stable only for Fermi levels between the two. The width of this window defines the U parameter,

$$\boxed{U \equiv \varepsilon(q/q-1) - \varepsilon(q+1/q) = E^f[X^{q+1}] + E^f[X^{q-1}] - 2E^f[X^q].} \tag{2.2}$$

The terms in E_F cancel, because $(q+1) + (q-1) - 2q = 0$, so U does not depend on the Fermi level.

U as a reaction energy. The right-hand side of the definition is the energy change of the disproportionation reaction

$$2X^q \to X^{q+1} + X^{q-1},$$

in which one defect passes an electron to another. The electron does not reach the reservoir, which explains why E_F drops out.

The sign of U. A second electron on the same defect feels the Coulomb repulsion of the first, which favors $U > 0$. The charge state q is then stable in a window of width U (Fig. 1a). The lattice around the defect can relax differently in each charge state, and a large relaxation can outweigh the repulsion, so that $U < 0$. The disproportionation then releases energy, the line of the charge state q lies above the crossing of the lines $q+1$ and $q-1$ for every E_F, and the defect changes directly from $q+1$ to $q-1$ at the level $\varepsilon(q+1/q-1)$ (Fig. 1b). The vacancy in silicon is an example, with an unstable V^+.

More charge states. With more than three charge states, the lower envelope selects the stable ones in order of decreasing charge from the VBM to the CBM. Each charge state that appears has a window of its own width, and a charge state with a negative U drops out, so that the envelope jumps by two units of slope at a single kink (Fig. 1c).

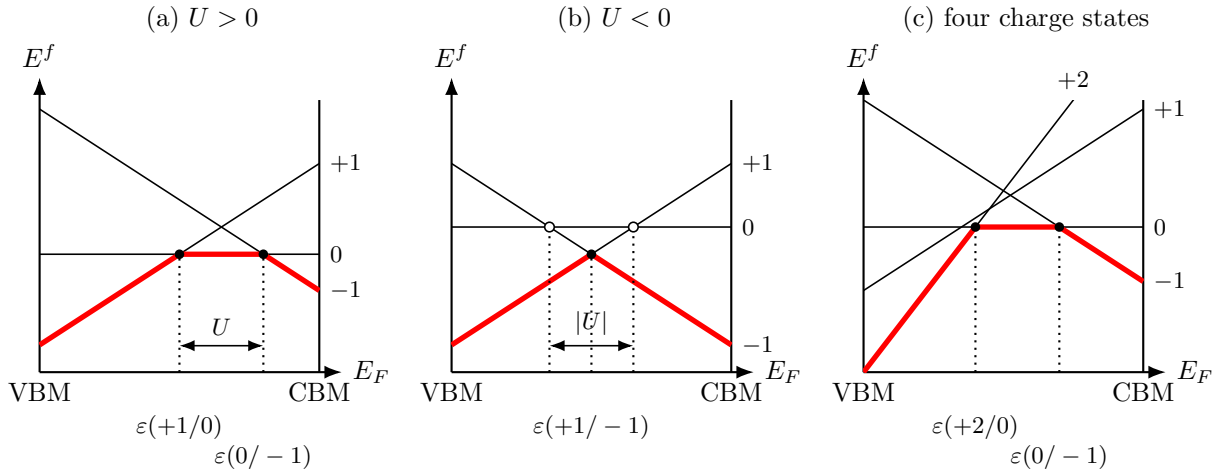


Figure 1: Formation energy against the Fermi level for three model defects, with the lower envelope in red. (a) Charge states +1, 0 and −1 with $U > 0$ and a window for the neutral state. (b) The same charge states with $U < 0$. Open circles: crossings with the neutral line above the envelope. (c) Charge states +2, +1, 0 and −1, with the state +1 skipped and a direct level $\varepsilon(+2/0)$.

3 Configurational Entropy and the Equilibrium Concentration

Counting the arrangements. Here, N denotes the number of lattice sites that a defect X can occupy, n the number of defects, and g_X the number of internal orientations of one defect on one site. Each site holds at most one defect, and each defect takes one of the g_X orientations. The i-th defect has $N-(i-1)$ free sites and g_X orientations to choose from, so n distinguishable defects have

$$\prod_{i=1}^{n} g_X\,(N-i+1) = g_X^n\,\frac{N!}{(N-n)!}$$

arrangements. The defects are identical, so the $n!$ permutations of the defects among the occupied sites give the same configuration. The number of distinct configurations is

$$\boxed{W = g_X^n \binom{N}{n} = g_X^n\,\frac{N!}{n!\,(N-n)!}.} \tag{3.1}$$

Configurational entropy. The configurational entropy counts the arrangements of the defects,

$$S_{\text{conf}} = k_B \ln W.$$

For large N and n, the Stirling approximation $\ln x! \approx x\ln x - x$ applies to each factorial. Here, $c \equiv n/N$ denotes the defect concentration per site and $s_{\text{conf}} \equiv S_{\text{conf}}/N$ the configurational entropy per site. The entropy is extensive, so s_{conf} depends on c only,

$$\boxed{s_{\text{conf}}(c) = -k_B\big[c\ln c + (1-c)\ln(1-c)\big] + k_B c \ln g_X.} \tag{3.2}$$

The first term is the mixing entropy of defects and empty sites, and the second term counts the orientations.

The dilute limit. Defect concentrations are usually small, $c \ll 1$. Then $\ln(1-c) \approx -c$, and the configurational entropy per site becomes

$$s_{\text{conf}}(c) \approx k_B\big[c\ln g_X - c\ln c + c\big].$$

The dilute result also follows directly from the product of the first paragraph. For $n \ll N$, every factor $N-i+1$ is close to N, so $W \approx (g_X N)^n/n!$, and the Stirling approximation for $n!$ alone gives the same s_{conf}.

The grand potential of a crystal with n defects. Section 1 places one defect at a fixed site, with the atoms and the electrons exchanged with the reservoirs at fixed $(T, V, \{\mu_i\}, E_F)$. The formation energy $E^f[X^q] = \Phi[X^q] - \Phi_{\text{bulk}}$ of that section is the change of the grand potential for this single defect. At finite temperature, E^f also contains the vibrational and electronic entropy of the defect, and the DFT expression of Section 1 is the limit $T \to 0$. Two assumptions extend the result to n defects. The defects are far apart and do not interact, so every arrangement has the grand potential $\Phi_{\text{bulk}} + nE^f[X^q]$, and each arrangement is equally probable. The sum over the W arrangements in the grand partition function then gives

$$\Phi(n) = \Phi_{\text{bulk}} + nE^f[X^q] - k_B T \ln W.$$

The configurational entropy enters through the sum over the arrangements, not through the formation energy of a single defect. Here, $\varphi \equiv \Phi/N$ denotes the grand potential per site. Per site,

$$\boxed{\varphi(c) = \varphi_{\text{bulk}} + c\, E^f[X^q] - T\, s_{\text{conf}}(c).} \tag{3.3}$$

The equilibrium concentration. The defects form and disappear freely, so c is an internal variable, and φ is a minimum at equilibrium,

$$\frac{\partial \varphi}{\partial c} = E^f[X^q] + k_B T \ln \frac{c}{1-c} - k_B T \ln g_X = 0.$$

The solution is

$$\boxed{\frac{c_{\text{eq}}}{1 - c_{\text{eq}}} = g_X\, e^{-E^f[X^q]/k_B T}, \qquad c_{\text{eq}} \approx g_X\, e^{-E^f[X^q]/k_B T} \quad (c_{\text{eq}} \ll 1).} \tag{3.4}$$

Fixed pressure instead of fixed volume. Experiments fix the pressure P, not the volume of the crystal. With P as the natural variable instead of V, the potential gains the term PV, and the formation energy gains $P\,\Delta V$, where ΔV is the volume change on forming the defect. At ambient pressure, $P\,\Delta V \approx 10^5$ Pa $\times\, 10^{-29}$ m$^3 \approx 10^{-5}$ eV, negligible against formation energies of the order of 1 eV. The results of this section therefore hold at fixed pressure as well. Freysoldt *et al.* write this potential as G and the formation energy at finite temperature as G^f, which correspond to Φ and E^f in these notes.